

ALTERNATIVE EDUCATION PROGRAMS

Loudoun County Public Schools offers alternative pathways to graduation through specialized programs offering instructional settings for high school students needing alternative completion opportunities and flexible methods towards earning a high school diploma or equivalent.

Alternative education programs enhance our ability to address graduation completion index, drop-out rate, and chronic absenteeism issues through personalized programming that meets the Standards of Accreditation (SOA) requirements.

A. Goals:

1. Provide sufficient resources to the personalized needs of the students in a suitable environment to best meet the unique needs of students.
2. Provide acceleration and/or additional time in achieving successful course completion to meet the unique needs of students. For example, acceleration may occur for students who enter Loudoun County Public Schools from a district, state, or country whose academic programming already allows for students to earn credits in less than one school year.
3. Educational accommodations will be made for English learners (EL), students with Individualized Education Plans (IEPs), and students with Section 504 plans.

B. Instruction. The instructional framework offered in the alternative education programs will be no less rigorous than a comparable, non-alternative high school setting. In addition, each course will meet secondary school accreditation requirements outlined by the Virginia Department of Education (VDOE). More specifically, the flexibility and personalization within these programs are targeted to assist students who may be pregnant or parenting, ELs who may have limited or interrupted formal education, older school-aged students working toward a high school diploma, and students needing to work during the traditional school day to support themselves or their families.

C. Credits. A student earning a passing grade in a course within the alternative education programs will earn credits for the course. Verified course credits will be earned when a student passes the End-of-Course SOL assessment associated with each course or earns a passing score on a state approved alternative assessment.

D. Student Eligibility. These programs are for those students in grades 9-12 (up to age 22 if eligible per Policy 8115). These alternative high school settings are

ALTERNATIVE EDUCATION PROGRAMS

recommended for students who are most at risk for dropping out of high school. Specifically, these may be:

1. Students who have experienced limited or interrupted formal education.
2. Students who require a smaller school setting.
3. Students who are credit-deficient based on age, grade level, and are out of sequence with cohort graduation requirements, and for whom such a deficiency cannot be addressed in a traditional school setting.
4. Students who struggle to earn the required verified credits via End-of-Course SOLs and the required CTE credential.
5. Students who require a flexible schedule due to personal challenges such as:
 - a. pregnancy, parenting, and other familial responsibilities,
 - b. homelessness,
 - c. socioeconomic pressures,
 - d. the immigration process,
 - e. other social/emotional issues that impact a student's focus and motivation
6. And/or any other student who may benefit from an alternative education model.

E. Accommodations. Educational accommodations will be made for English Learners (ELs), students with Individualized Educational Plans (IEPs), and qualified students with Section 504 plans.

F. Referral. A student may self-refer or be referred to these programs. Any student who wishes to enroll will find information and application procedures at each high school's Counseling Office and on the LCPS webpage. Parents or guardians may request, in consultation with the high school principal or designee, student placement in these individual programs, and shall complete the appropriate application procedures. Principals or designees referring students to alternative programs may do so if the student is in jeopardy of dropping out or failing to meet graduation requirements within their graduation cohort.

ALTERNATIVE EDUCATION PROGRAMS

G. Placement. The Superintendent or their designee will place referred students in Alternative Education Programs based on the individual student's progress toward earning a high school diploma, student eligibility, and programmatic enrollment capacity. Before placing a student in an involuntarily alternative education, a written notice will be sent to the student, parent and/or legal guardian of the placement intent. The written notice provides an opportunity for the family to participate in a hearing regarding the placement. The Superintendent or designee's decision shall be final unless altered by the School Board upon petition for a review on the record. A student who is enrolled in the alternative high school will not be concurrently enrolled in a home high school.

H. Involuntary Transfer. An involuntary transfer occurs when a student is moved from one school to another as determined by the Superintendent's designee. Per school board policy 8220, Student Suspension From School, the superintendent's designee reserves the right to transfer involuntarily a student from one school/alternative education program to another when the student has committed acts specified in Policy 8210, Introduction to Student Discipline, Subsection F, when normal disciplinary measures, including suspension from school, have failed to correct such behavior, or a single act of such behavior is deemed by the Superintendent's designee to warrant a transfer.

Adopted: 8/10/21

Legal Refs: Code of Virginia §§ [22.1-253.13:4](#), [22.1-5](#), [22.1-79.1](#), [22.1-269.1](#), [22.1-277.2:2](#), [22.1-254](#)

Cross Ref.: Policy [8220](#), Student Suspension from School, Policy [8115](#), Individuals Who May Be Admitted Free